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# Strengths Insight and Action-Planning Guide

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## Your Top 5 Themes

Restorative  
Achiever  
Analytical  
Individualization  
Competition

## What's in This Guide?

### [Section I: Awareness](#)

- A brief Shared Theme Description for each of your top five themes
- Your Personalized Strengths Insights, which describe what makes you stand out from others with the same theme in their top five
- Questions for you to answer to increase your awareness of your talents

### [Section II: Application](#)

- 10 Ideas for Action for each of your top five themes
- Questions for you to answer to help you apply your talents

### [Section III: Achievement](#)

- Examples of what each of your top five themes "sounds like" -- real quotes from people who also have the theme in their top five
- Steps for you to take to help you leverage your talents for achievement

## Section I: Awareness

### Restorative

#### Shared Theme Description

People who are especially talented in the Restorative theme are adept at dealing with problems. They are good at figuring out what is wrong and resolving it.

#### Your Personalized Strengths Insights

*What makes you stand out?*

Instinctively, you enjoy passing time with people who foresee what will be possible weeks, months, years, or decades from now. You use reason to decide whether their inventive ideas are doable and sensible. You dissect their thoughts and plans into their basic parts. Because you are determined to make things better, you spend time perfecting the suggestions of these future-oriented individuals. You are determined to eliminate any problems before they happen. Because of your strengths, you are fascinated with the way things operate. You frequently have insights about how to upgrade a process, mechanism, regulation, program, or project. Individuals, situations, and things have benefited from your betterment plans. It's very likely that you guide people by offering them your advice and suggestions. You probably tell them about areas in which they would be wise to enhance, upgrade, or expand their knowledge or skills. You prefer to point out deficiencies. Then you help individuals eradicate — that is, remove or wipe out — all traces of deficiencies. You probably use this “fix it” approach on yourself, too. By nature, you rarely avoid telling people about yourself, your experiences, or even your shortcomings. You reflect on what you should do better, more completely, or more perfectly. You are comfortable admitting all sorts of things about yourself. Chances are good that you are honest with yourself about yourself. You can admit your shortcomings. You speak frankly about the areas where you need to do things better and more completely than you have done them in the past.

#### Questions

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

## Achiever

### Shared Theme Description

People who are especially talented in the Achiever theme have a great deal of stamina and work hard. They take great satisfaction from being busy and productive.

### Your Personalized Strengths Insights

*What makes you stand out?*

It's very likely that you now and then create daily rituals or repetitious patterns of behavior to make progress. Perhaps these familiar procedures allow you to sequence the steps of certain projects, programs, or processes. Maybe you want to do some things in an orderly or efficient manner. Because of your strengths, you normally launch projects with ease. You methodically identify pertinent facts and establish a step-by-step workflow. This probably is the way you prefer to reach desirable goals. Instinctively, you normally tackle projects with gusto. New assignments or challenges energize your life. Facing mundane, tedious, or routine chores day after day eventually undermines your upbeat attitude. Driven by your talents, you can mentally zero in on tasks for hours at a time when you have a goal to reach. When the assignment demands extra time, you would be wise to honor your body's natural rhythms. In other words, if you are a "morning person," work in the morning. Work in the afternoon if that is when you hit your stride. Work in the evening if that is when you think better. Work around midnight after everyone has gone to bed if you are someone who usually stays up very late. By nature, you sometimes labor long and hard to produce excellent results. You might need to have a lot of independence, solitude, or control over assignments.

### Questions

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2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

## Analytical

### Shared Theme Description

People who are especially talented in the Analytical theme search for reasons and causes. They have the ability to think about all the factors that might affect a situation.

### Your Personalized Strengths Insights

*What makes you stand out?*

Driven by your talents, you may be earnest, solemn, or businesslike when circumstances require socially correct behavior. Perhaps you thoroughly study certain things before making decisions, designing plans, or taking action. By nature, you generally rely on reason to determine how an event, decision, or condition led to an outcome. You usually desire to understand how things converge to produce the final result. Instinctively, you normally recruit people to work on projects or teams. You probably outline reasons for their participation. Frequently you emphasize the benefits of signing up to do something. Because of your strengths, you are well aware of the many elements impacting a group of people, a project, a process, a deal, or a proposal. Typically you examine all the facts to predict possible outcomes or consequences. You probably produce reasonable explanations for why things do and do not happen. It's very likely that you probably describe your life as wonderful, especially when you are encouraged to investigate in detail a variety of subjects and situations.

### Questions

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

## Individualization

### Shared Theme Description

People who are especially talented in the Individualization theme are intrigued with the unique qualities of each person. They have a gift for figuring out how people who are different can work together productively.

### Your Personalized Strengths Insights

*What makes you stand out?*

Instinctively, you often help visionaries discover ways they can work with people who concentrate on the past or the present. Rather than let differences separate them, you point out areas where they share similar backgrounds, work styles, talents, or interests. You understand the loneliness that forward-looking people can experience when listeners call their ideas “far-fetched,” “impractical,” or “ridiculous.” You are quick to show people how their unique traits complement each other. By nature, you often marvel at your ability to sense the feelings and perspectives of other people. You feel very good about yourself and life in general when you put aside your opinions, biases, or preferences. Your satisfaction probably comes from figuring out why someone behaves, feels, or thinks differently than you do. It’s very likely that you frequently examine the factors leading up to an event. Therein you discover the reasons why things happened the way they did. A number of individuals and/or groups probably appreciate your logical thinking style. Driven by your talents, you prefer to concentrate on activities, problems, opportunities, or subjects that really intrigue you. Each time you acquire new information, you feel you can help people who need the same information. Chances are good that you frequently promise yourself to do something better than you did it the last time. As you examine the consequences of your words and deeds, you usually recognize ways you could perform a similar task or problem the next time with a higher degree of knowledge or skill. Simply put: You are determined to gain insights from your mistakes so you do not repeat them.

### Questions

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

## Competition

### Shared Theme Description

People who are especially talented in the Competition theme measure their progress against the performance of others. They strive to win first place and revel in contests.

### Your Personalized Strengths Insights

*What makes you stand out?*

By nature, you refuse to be content with your performance until you have been declared the most capable, successful, or accomplished person in the group. Just knowing you are being compared to others gives you the extra energy and determination you need to surpass everyone else's performance. Chances are good that you invest time in getting to know people as individuals. Although it might not be your intention, the insights you gain often allow you to outwit and outmaneuver others. It's very likely that you might be methodical about preparing for events where your strengths are going to be tested against those of others. Maybe you outline the details of a practice schedule and attempt to follow them. On most days, you may increase your knowledge, skills, or endurance. Perhaps you have stick-to-itiveness — that is, dogged perseverance — to get ready. Your training may be a bit more rigorous than that of others. Instinctively, you notice that your ability to use common sense and reason gives you an edge — that is, an advantage — over many people. You are driven from within — that is, you motivate yourself — to accomplish more and do better work than you ever have. This is your path to success. Because of your strengths, you might establish step-by-step performance targets for yourself. Perhaps keeping each week's tasks or goals in mind improves your chances of finishing in first place or being declared the best.

### Questions

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2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

## Questions

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1. How does this information help you better understand your unique talents?
2. How can you use this understanding to add value to your role?
3. How can you apply this knowledge to add value to your team, workgroup, department, or division?
4. How will this understanding help you add value to your organization?
5. What will you do differently tomorrow as a result of this report?

## Section II: Application

### Restorative

#### Ideas for Action:

- Seek roles in which you are paid to solve problems or in which your success depends on your ability to restore and resolve. You might particularly enjoy roles in medicine, consulting, computer programming, or customer service.
- Don't be afraid to let others know that you enjoy fixing problems. It comes naturally to you, but many people shy away from problems. You can help.
- Give yourself a break. Your Restorative talents might lead you to be overly self-critical. Try to redirect this either toward things about yourself that can be fixed, such as knowledge or skill deficits, or toward external, tangible problems.
- Let other people solve their own problems. You might want to rush in and solve things for them, but by doing that, you might hinder their learning. Watch out for this, particularly if you are in a manager, coach, teacher, or parent role.
- Turnaround situations activate your natural forté. Use your Restorative talents to devise a plan of attack to revitalize a flagging project, organization, business, or team.
- Leverage your Restorative talents not only to tackle existing problems, but also to anticipate and prevent problems before they occur. Share your foresight and your solutions with others, and you will prove yourself a valuable partner.
- Study your chosen subject closely to become adept at identifying what causes certain problems to recur. This sort of expertise will lead you to the solution that much faster.
- Think about ways you can improve your skills and knowledge. Identify any gaps you have and the courses you can take to fill them.
- Constant improvement is one of your hallmarks. Seek opportunities to enhance your abilities through a demanding field, activity, or endeavor that requires exceptional skill and/or knowledge.
- Use your Restorative talents to think of ways to “problem proof” your work. Identify existing and potential issues, and design systems or processes to prevent errors in the future.

#### Questions

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.



## Achiever

### Ideas for Action:

- Select jobs that allow you to have the leeway to work as hard as you want and in which you are encouraged to measure your own productivity. You will feel challenged and alive in these environments.
- As an achiever, you relish the feeling of being busy, yet you also need to know when you are “done.” Attach timelines and measurement to goals so that effort leads to defined progress and tangible outcomes.
- Remember to build celebration and recognition into your life. Achievers tend to move on to the next challenge without acknowledging their successes. Counter this impulse by creating regular opportunities to enjoy your progress and accomplishments.
- Your drive for action might cause you to find meetings a bit boring. If that’s the case, appeal to your Achiever talents by learning the objectives of each meeting ahead of time and by taking notes about progress toward those objectives during the meeting. You can help ensure that meetings are productive and efficient.
- Continue your education by attaining certifications in your area or specialty in addition to attending conferences and other programs. This will give you even more goals to achieve and will push your existing boundaries of accomplishment.
- You do not require much motivation from others. Take advantage of your self-motivation by setting challenging goals. Set a more demanding goal every time you finish a project.
- Partner with other hard workers. Share your goals with them so they can help you to get more done.
- Count personal achievements in your scoring “system.” This will help you direct your Achiever talents toward family and friends as well as toward work.
- More work excites you. The prospect of what lies ahead is infinitely more motivating than what has been completed. Launch initiatives and new projects. Your seemingly endless reserve of energy will create enthusiasm and momentum.
- Make sure that in your eagerness to do more at work, you do not skimp on quality. Create measurable outcome standards to guarantee that increased productivity is matched by enhanced quality.

### Questions

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## Analytical

### Ideas for Action:

- Choose work in which you are paid to analyze data, find patterns, or organize ideas. For example, you might excel in marketing, financial, or medical research or in database management, editing, or risk management.
- Whatever your role, identify credible sources on which you can rely. You are at your best when you have well-researched sources of information and numbers to support your logic. For example, determine the most helpful books, websites, or publications that can serve as references.
- Your mind is constantly working and producing insightful analysis. Are others aware of that? Find the best way of expressing your thoughts: writing, one-on-one conversations, group discussions, perhaps lectures or presentations. Put value to your thoughts by communicating them.
- Make sure that your accumulation and analysis of information always leads to its application and implementation. If you don't do this naturally, find a partner who pushes you from theory to practice, from thinking to doing. This person will help ensure that your analysis doesn't turn into paralysis.
- Take an academic course that will expand your Analytical talents. Specifically, study people whose logic you admire.
- Volunteer your Analytical talents. You can be particularly helpful to those who are struggling to organize large quantities of data or having a hard time bringing structure to their ideas.
- Partner with someone with strong Activator talents. This person's impatience will move you more quickly through the analytical phase into the action phase.
- You may remain skeptical until you see solid proof. Your skepticism ensures validity, but others may take it personally. Help others realize that your skepticism is primarily about data, not people.
- Look for patterns in data. See if you can discern a motif, precedent, or relationship in scores or numbers. By connecting the dots in the data and inferring a causal link, you may be able to help others see these patterns.
- Help others understand that your analytical approach will often require data and other information to logically back up new ideas that they might suggest.

### Questions

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

## Individualization

### Ideas for Action:

- Select a vocation in which your Individualization talents can be both used and appreciated, such as counseling, supervising, teaching, writing human interest articles, or selling. Your ability to see people as unique individuals is a special talent.
- Become an expert in describing your own strengths and style. For example, answer questions such as: What is the best praise you ever received? How often do you like to check in with your manager? What is your best method for building relationships? How do you learn best? Then ask your colleagues and friends these same questions. Help them plan their future by starting with their strengths, then designing a future based on what they do best.
- Help others understand that true diversity can be found in the subtle differences between each individual — regardless of race, sex, or nationality.
- Explain that it is appropriate, just, and effective to treat each person differently. Those without strong Individualization talents might not see the differences among individuals and might insist that individualization is unequal and therefore unfair. You will need to describe your perspective in detail to be persuasive.
- Figure out what every person on your team does best. Then help them capitalize on their talents, skills, and knowledge. You may need to explain your rationale and your philosophy so people understand that you have their best interests in mind.
- You have an awareness and appreciation of others' likes and dislikes and an ability to personalize. This puts you in a unique position. Use your Individualization talents to help identify areas where one size does not fit all.
- Make your colleagues and friends aware of each person's unique needs. Soon people will look to you to explain other people's motivations and actions.
- Your presentations and speaking opportunities will be most engaging when you relate your topic to the experiences of individuals in the audience. Use your Individualization talents to gather and share real-life stories that will make your points much better than would generic information or theories.
- You move comfortably among a broad range of styles and cultures, and you intuitively personalize your interactions. Consciously and proactively make full use of these talents by leading diversity and community efforts.
- Your Individualization talents can help you take a different approach to interpreting data. While others are looking for similarities, make a point of identifying distinctiveness. Your interpretations will add a valuable perspective.

### Questions

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

## Competition

### Ideas for Action:

- Select work environments in which you can measure your achievements. You might not be able to discover how good you can be without competing.
- List the performance scores that help you know where you stand every day. What scores should you pay attention to?
- Identify a high-achieving person against whom you can measure your own achievement. If there is more than one, list all the people with whom you currently compete. Without measurement, how will you know if you won?
- Try to turn ordinary tasks into competitive games. You will get more done this way.
- When you win, take the time to investigate why you won. You can learn a great deal more from a victory than from a loss.
- Let people know that being competitive does not equate with putting others down. Explain that you derive satisfaction from pitting yourself against good, strong competitors and winning.
- Develop a “balanced metric” — a measurement system that will monitor all aspects of your performance. Even if you are competing against your own previous numbers, this measurement will help you give proper attention to all aspects of your performance.
- When competing with others, create development opportunities by choosing to compare yourself to someone who is slightly above your current level of expertise. Your competition will push you to refine your skills and knowledge to exceed those of that person. Look one or two levels above you for a role model who will push you to improve.
- Take the time to celebrate your wins. In your world, there is no victory without celebration.
- Design some mental strategies that can help you deal with a loss. Armed with these strategies, you will be able to move on to the next challenge much more quickly.

### Questions

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

### Section III: Achievement

Look for signs of achievement as you read these real quotes from people who share your top five themes.

Restorative sounds like this:

Nigel L., software designer: “I have these vivid memories of my childhood woodworking bench with hammers and nails and wood. I used to love fixing things and putting things together and making everything just so. And now with computer programs, it’s the same thing. You write the program, and if it doesn’t work, you have to go back and redo it and fix it until it works.”

Jan K., internist: “This theme plays in my life in so many ways. For example, my first love was surgery. I love trauma, love being in the OR, love sewing. I just love fixing things in the OR. Then again, some of my best moments have been sitting at the bedside of a dying patient, just talking together. It is incredibly rewarding to watch someone make the transition from anger to acceptance about grief, to tie up loose ends with family members, and to pass with dignity. And then with my kids, this theme fires every day. When I see my three-year-old buttoning her sweater for the first time and she buttons it crooked, I feel this powerful urge to walk up and rebutton the sweater. I have to resist, of course, because she has to learn, but, boy, it’s really hard.”

Marie T., television producer: “Producing a morning TV program is a fundamentally clumsy process. If I didn’t like solving problems, this job would drive me up the wall. Every day, something serious goes wrong, and I have to find the problem, fix it, and move on to the next one. If I can do that well, I feel rejuvenated. On the other hand, if I go home and a problem remains unsolved, then I feel the opposite. I feel defeated.”

### Achiever sounds like this:

Melanie K., ER nurse: "I have to rack up points every day to feel successful. Today I've been here only half an hour, but I've probably racked up thirty points already. I ordered equipment for the ER, I had equipment repaired, I had a meeting with my charge nurse, and I brainstormed with my secretary about improving our computerized logbook. So on my list of ninety things, I have thirty done already. I'm feeling pretty good about myself right now."

Ted S., salesperson: "Last year I was salesperson of the year out of my company's three hundred salespeople. It felt good for a day, but sure enough, later that week, it was as if it never happened. I was back at zero again. Sometimes I wish I wasn't an achiever because it can lead me away from a balanced life and toward obsession. I used to think I could change myself, but now I know I am just wired this way. This theme is truly a double-edged sword. It helps me achieve my goals, but on the other hand, I wish I could just turn it off and on at will. But, hey, I can't. I can manage it and avoid work obsession by focusing on achieving in all parts of my life, not just work."

Sara L., writer: "This theme is a weird one. First, it's good because you live in pursuit of the perpetual challenge. But in the second place, you never feel as though you've reached your goal. It can keep you running uphill at seventy miles an hour for your whole life. You never rest because there's always more to do. But, on balance, I think I would rather have it than not. I call it my 'divine restlessness,' and if it makes me feel as if I owe the present everything I have, then so be it. I can live with that."

## Analytical sounds like this:

Jose G., school system administrator: "I have an innate ability to see structures, formats, and patterns before they exist. For instance, when people are talking about writing a grant proposal, while I'm listening to them, my brain instinctively processes the type of grants that are available and how the discussion fits into the eligibility, right down to the format of how the information can fit on the grant form in a clear and convincing way."

Jack T., human resources executive: "If I make a claim, I need to know that I can back it up with facts and logical thinking. For example, if someone says that our company is not paying as much as other companies, I always ask, 'Why do you say that?' If they say, 'Well, I saw an ad in the paper that offers graduates in mechanical engineering five grand more than we are paying,' I'll reply by asking, 'But where are these graduates going to work? Is their salary based on geography? What types of companies are they going for? Are they manufacturing companies like ours? And how many people are in their sample? Is it three people, and one of them got a really good deal, thus driving the overall average up?' There are many questions I need to ask to ensure that their claim is indeed a fact and not based on one misleading data point."

Leslie J., school principal: "Many times, there are inconsistencies in the performance of the same group of students from one year to the next. It's the same group of kids, but their scores are different year to year. How can this be? Which building are the kids in? How many of the kids have been enrolled for a full academic year? Which teachers were they assigned to, and what teaching styles were used by those teachers? I just love asking questions like these to understand what is truly happening."

### Individualization sounds like this:

Les T., hospitality manager: “Carl is one of our best performers, but he still has to see me every week. He just wants a little encouragement and to check in, and he gets fired up a little bit after that meeting. Greg doesn’t like to meet very often, so there’s no need for me to bother him. And when we do meet, it’s really for me, not for him.”

Marsha D., publishing executive: “Sometimes I would walk out of my office and — you know how cartoon characters have those balloons over their head? I would see these little balloons over everyone’s head telling me what was in their minds. It sounds weird, doesn’t it? But it happens all the time.”

Andrea H., interior designer: “When you ask people what their style is, they find it hard to describe, so I just ask them, ‘What is your favorite spot in the house?’ And when I ask that, their faces light up, and they know just where to take me. From that one spot, I can begin to piece together the kind of people they are and what their style is.”



## Competition sounds like this:

Mark L., sales executive: "I've played sports my entire life, and I don't just play to have fun — let me put it that way. I like to engage in sports I am going to win and not ones I am going to lose, because if I lose, I am outwardly gracious but inwardly infuriated."

Harry D., general manager: "I'm not a big sailor, but I love the America's Cup. Both boats are supposed to be exactly the same, and both crews have top-notch athletes. But you always get a winner. One of them had some secret up their sleeves that tipped the balance and enabled them to win more often than lose. And that's what I am looking for — that secret, that tiny edge."

Sumner Redstone, chairman of Viacom (now known as CBS Corporation), on his efforts to acquire that company: "I relished every minute of it because Viacom was a company worth fighting for and I enjoyed a contest. If you get involved in a major competitive struggle, and the stress that inevitably comes with it, you'd better derive some real sense of satisfaction and enjoyment from the ultimate victory. Wrestling control of a company like Viacom was warfare. I believe the real lesson it taught me was that it is not about money, it's about the will to win."

## Questions

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1. Talk to friends or coworkers to hear how they have used their talents to achieve.
2. How will you use your talents to achieve?